

Emotional Wellbeing

Understanding emotional health and evidence-based ways to strengthen it

Introduction

Emotional wellbeing is a core part of overall mental health. It shapes how people experience daily life, handle setbacks, and connect with others. This document explains what emotional wellbeing means, the factors that influence it, and practical, evidence-based ways to strengthen it over time.

What is Emotional Wellbeing?

Mental health includes emotional, psychological, and social well-being. It affects how people think, feel, and act as they cope with life, and it helps determine how they handle stress, relate to others, and make choices. Mental health, including emotional wellbeing, is important at every stage of life, from childhood and adolescence through adulthood and older age.

(Source: MedlinePlus)

Emotional wellbeing is not the same as constant happiness. Staying positive does not mean never feeling negative emotions, such as sadness or anger; these emotions are a normal part of life and can actually help a person process and deal with problems. Emotional wellbeing instead involves finding a balance between positive and negative emotions and being able to cope effectively with both.

(Source: MedlinePlus)

The Mental Health Foundation (UK) describes mental health as the way people think and feel and their ability to deal with the ups and downs of life. Everyone has mental health, just as everyone has physical health, and there are times when a person's mental health is better than at other times. When a person enjoys good mental health, they have a sense of purpose and direction, the energy to do the things they want to do, and the ability to deal with life's challenges.

(Source: Mental Health Foundation UK)

What Influences Emotional Wellbeing

Emotional wellbeing is shaped by a combination of biological, psychological, and social factors that interact over the course of a person's life.

(Source: MedlinePlus)

- Biological factors, such as genes and brain chemistry.

- Physical health, since physical and mental health are closely connected; for example, poor sleep can affect mood, and regular exercise can reduce stress and depression.
- Life experiences, including difficult or stressful events, such as trauma, loss, or major life changes.
- Relationships and social connection, since strong, healthy relationships can help protect against stress.
- A sense of meaning and purpose, which can come from work, volunteering, learning new skills, or personal beliefs.
- Ongoing circumstances, such as managing a chronic illness, caring for a family member, or financial strain, which can wear down a person's ability to cope over time.

(Source: MedlinePlus)

Common Signs of Poor Emotional Wellbeing

It can be hard to know what is a normal emotional reaction and what may signal a need for extra support. Common signs that emotional wellbeing may be struggling include the following.

(Source: MedlinePlus)

- Persistent low mood, irritability, or anxiety that lasts for weeks.
- Difficulty coping with everyday stress or challenges that were previously manageable.
- Withdrawal from relationships and activities that used to bring enjoyment.
- Changes in sleep, appetite, or energy levels.
- Difficulty concentrating or making decisions.
- A persistent sense of being overwhelmed or unable to cope.

(Source: MedlinePlus)

Evidence-Based Ways to Support Emotional Wellbeing

Building a Positive Outlook

Staying positive is the habit of seeing the good in situations and expecting things to work out well. It does not mean ignoring negative emotions, but rather finding balance between positive and negative feelings. Practicing gratitude, meaning being thankful for the good things in life, is one way to build a positive outlook; this can be done by thinking about, or writing down, things a person is grateful for, whether large, such as support from loved ones, or small, such as enjoying a good meal.

(Source: MedlinePlus)

Taking Care of Physical Health

Physical and mental health are closely connected. Being physically active reduces feelings of stress and depression and improves mood. Getting enough sleep supports mood, since a lack of quality sleep over time can make a person more likely to become depressed. Eating a well-balanced diet may help improve

mood and decrease anxiety and stress, and getting enough of certain nutrients may help protect against some mental health conditions.

(Source: MedlinePlus)

Connecting With Others

Connecting with others is important, since strong, healthy relationships may help protect against stress. It is also helpful to have different types of connections, including family, friends, and community or neighborhood involvement, such as volunteering for a local organization or joining a group centered on a shared hobby or interest.

(Source: MedlinePlus)

Developing a Sense of Meaning and Purpose

Developing a sense of meaning and purpose in life, which could come through a job, volunteering, learning new skills, or exploring one's spirituality, supports long-term emotional health.

(Source: MedlinePlus)

Ten Evidence-Based Ways to Look After Mental Health

The Mental Health Foundation (UK) provides evidence-based tips for looking after mental health that can be applied by most people in everyday life.

(Source: Mental Health Foundation UK)

- Talk about your feelings, since talking can help maintain mental health and manage difficult times.
- Stay physically active through activities such as sport, dancing, cycling, walking, or gardening, which release hormones that reduce feelings of stress and anger and can improve sleep.
- Spend time in nature, since research suggests that connecting with green or natural spaces can have a calming effect and is associated with feeling calmer, more hopeful, and less alone.
- Eat well, since diet can influence mood and energy levels.
- Keep in touch with people who matter to you, and consider reaching out for support with financial or other practical problems that may be affecting your mental health.
- Ask for help when things are difficult rather than trying to manage alone.
- Take a break and give yourself time to rest and recharge.
- Do something you are good at, since engaging in enjoyable or meaningful activities supports wellbeing.
- Accept who you are, since everyone is different and self-acceptance is part of good mental health.
- Care for others, since supporting people around you can also strengthen your own sense of connection and purpose.

(Source: Mental Health Foundation UK)

Self-Help Techniques

- Practice gratitude regularly, such as writing down a few things you are grateful for each day.
- Use relaxation techniques, such as deep breathing, meditation, or muscle relaxation, to manage difficult emotions.
- Maintain a regular routine for sleep, meals, and activity, since consistency supports emotional stability.
- Talk to someone you trust about how you are feeling, since being heard and understood can ease distress.
- Set realistic goals and celebrate small achievements along the way.
- Limit exposure to sources of stress when possible, such as taking breaks from news or social media that negatively affect your mood.

(Source: MedlinePlus, Mental Health Foundation UK)

When to Seek Professional Help

Self-help strategies can support emotional wellbeing, but it is important to recognize when professional support is needed.

(Source: MedlinePlus)

- Low mood, anxiety, or emotional distress that persists for weeks and does not improve.
- Difficulty carrying out everyday activities, work, or relationships because of how you are feeling.
- Increasing reliance on alcohol, drugs, or other unhealthy behaviors to cope.
- A sense that self-help strategies are not enough to manage current stress or emotional difficulties.
- Any thoughts of self-harm or suicide, which require immediate professional help.

(Source: MedlinePlus)

If a person thinks they may have a mental health problem, a good starting point is to talk with a primary care provider, who can help identify appropriate next steps, including referral to a mental health professional.

(Source: MedlinePlus)

Myths vs Facts

- Myth: Emotional wellbeing means always feeling happy. Fact: Emotional wellbeing involves a healthy balance between positive and negative emotions, not the absence of difficult feelings.
- Myth: Looking after your mental health requires major lifestyle changes. Fact: Many evidence-based steps, such as talking about feelings, spending time outdoors, or staying connected with others, are simple and can be built into everyday life.

- Myth: Asking for help is a sign of weakness. Fact: Asking for help when things are difficult is one of the recommended, evidence-based ways to look after mental health.
- Myth: Only people with a diagnosed mental illness need to think about emotional wellbeing. Fact: Everyone has mental health and can benefit from actively looking after their emotional wellbeing, regardless of whether they have a diagnosed condition.

(Source: MedlinePlus, Mental Health Foundation UK)

Frequently Asked Questions

Q: Is it normal to feel sad or anxious sometimes?

A: Yes. Negative emotions such as sadness or anger are a normal part of life and can help a person deal with problems. Emotional wellbeing is about finding balance, not eliminating negative emotions entirely.

(Source: MedlinePlus)

Q: How does physical health affect emotional wellbeing?

A: Physical and mental health are closely connected. Regular physical activity, good sleep, and a balanced diet can all improve mood and reduce stress, anxiety, and the risk of depression.

(Source: MedlinePlus)

Q: What is one simple step I can take today to support my emotional wellbeing?

A: Talking about your feelings with someone you trust is a simple, evidence-based way to support your mental health and manage difficult times.

(Source: Mental Health Foundation UK)

Q: When should I seek professional support rather than relying on self-help?

A: Professional support should be sought if low mood, anxiety, or distress persists for weeks, interferes with daily life, or if self-help strategies are not enough, and always if there are any thoughts of self-harm or suicide.

(Source: MedlinePlus)

Key Takeaways

- Emotional wellbeing is a core part of mental health and involves balancing positive and negative emotions rather than avoiding difficult feelings.
- Emotional wellbeing is shaped by biological, psychological, and social factors that interact over time.
- Evidence-based ways to support emotional wellbeing include staying physically active, connecting with others, practicing gratitude, spending time in nature, and developing a sense of purpose.
- Talking about feelings and asking for help are recommended, healthy ways to manage difficult times, not signs of weakness.

- Persistent or severe emotional distress, or any thoughts of self-harm, warrant professional support.

This document provides general educational information based on publicly available guidance from MedlinePlus and the Mental Health Foundation (UK). It is not a substitute for personalized medical advice, diagnosis, or treatment. Always consult a qualified health care provider with questions about a specific medical condition.

References

- How to Improve Mental Health — MedlinePlus. <https://medlineplus.gov/howtoimprovementalhealth.html>
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